

Karigars to *krantikaris*

A technology superpower – that’s what India’s been touted as, for quite a while now. Before the whole recession worries came about, everyone and their uncles were outsourcing to India. I’m not talking just about the good old call centre, which is what first springs to mind when you hear the word “outsourcing”, but also all the trillions of lines of code that Indians have been writing for companies across the globe. Whether as software services, game development, animation, and more, Indians are contributing to the world in a huge way. The software services industry has made a lot of money this way, and contributed to our economy, but we’re still not growing the way we should. We’re still not a true tech superpower.

In our cover story this month, as our way of celebrating this year’s Independence Day, we’re talking about innovations – quite frankly, we need some desperately.

First, let me give you a little insight into where I’m coming from. For over a decade, I’ve been an IRC junkie, and have interacted with strangers from all over the world. I’ve seen people’s perceptions about India, and Indians in general, change drastically in this timeframe.

About 13 years ago, when people found out I was Indian, I actually had to respond to questions like, “Do you own a monkey?”, and “Are there really cows and elephants on the streets?”, and some others I’d rather not discuss. Regardless, the perceptions were obvious.

Things then transitioned to, “Indian women are beautiful!” when some of our women started winning beauty pageants. Today, the reaction is more like, “What do you do? Are you a coder?” or “Do you work in a call centre?”.

Should I consider this a step up for me? Going from monkey-trainer to code-monkey in the eyes of the west?

I have nothing against the software services industry, and I think they’re doing an excellent job. However, we need to *create* more. We need made in India products that the world wants – software, hardware, concepts, anything. That’s where innovation comes in. And it starts in India, for Indians.

How many people in the west would understand the problems you face on a daily basis? How many of them would understand the great language divide that separates India much like the state lines on maps?

From conversations I’ve had with Indians who live abroad, as well as those who live here, the frustration is quite apparent. Some actually feel we’re nothing more than a sweatshop for the work that no one in the west wants to do – we are nothing more than cheap labour. “When,” I’ve been asked, “will India outsource mundane coding to the west, and choose to do the fun stuff here?” Honestly, I have no clue when, but I have to believe that it will happen.

The timing’s just right. We’ve got a whole generation of technology professionals all set to hit the market. Investments are coming in, Indian hardware vendors have started cropping up (mostly in the mobile segments, but there’s hope this will diversify), and the software professionals are almost seasoned veterans now. All we need are ideas, innovations and more attention to detail, and we could have our own success stories – companies that can stand shoulder to shoulder with the Googles, Microsofts and Apples of the world. That’s the reason for those two little words you saw on the cover.

Tech Kranti is our way of saying that we need to revolutionise the way we work, think and live. Think of ways in which you can improve lives here in India, and you will have a successful idea that you can market. Although there’s easy money to be made in the outsourcing world, building something here could be more rewarding in the long run. Plus, wouldn’t you like your revenue to not be dependent on bad policy decisions made by a few bankers thousands of miles away?

Perhaps it’s time you started thinking of yourself as a revolutionary, instead of a craftsman. What’s the difference? A craftsman is good at his work, but usually builds someone else’s idea... a revolutionary, on the other hand, would come up with an idea, employ a lot of craftsmen, and build something memorable... time to evolve from *karigars* to a *krantikaris*...

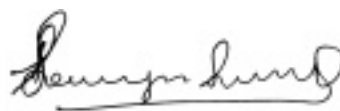
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Jai Hind! 



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